enthralled as the emperor by these trained birds. ‘It will seem little short of miraculous,’ he writes, ‘when I affirm that when sent out, they dance, turn somersaults all together in the air, fly in orderly rhythm, and return to their starting point, all at the sound of a whistle. They are bidden to perch on the roof, to conceal themselves within their nesting-places, or to dart out of them again; and they do everything just as they are told.’ It wasn’t only tricks that pigeons were good for. The *Ain-i-Akbari* records that some had peculiar calls, other distinctive struts; and, of course, some were ‘*rath*’ pigeons that could deliver messages.

Akbar had ‘khasa’ pigeons, naturally – 500 out of his collection of 20,000 were specially chosen by the emperor. They came in many beautiful colours – *chini* (porcelain blue), *surmai* (dark grey), *kishmishi* (dark brown), *halwai* (light brown), *shaftalu* (peach), *kaghazi* (paper-yellow). His favourite was Mohana, given to him by Aziz; and Mohana’s various progeny – Askhi, Parizad, Almas and more – filled Akbar’s dovecotes.[33]

One or more of them may have been flying about this August noon, as Akbar stood on his roof, ‘admiring [their] wonderful movements’. His mind was full of their flap and call when one of his amirs came up and told him the news.

Akbar, says an eyewitness, fainted where he stood.

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Some six-odd years before, Akbar had had another of his accidents, this time during a deer fight. One of the contending stags attacked the emperor, butting him with his antlers, and managed to gore one of his testicles. It was Abul Fazl who tended to him, applying balm to his wound over the long and anxious weeks of his recovery until, after a month and twenty-two days, Akbar finally bathed.[34]

No metaphor, even of Abul Fazl’s devising, could have better captured the intimacy between the two men. This was how much Akbar, who would not let poor Jouher see him naked, who would stab himself to prove his courage, trusted his historian. Akbar ‘never forgave [Salim]’ the murder of his friend, writes Inayatullah; and for the rest of his life, the emperor would send out vengeful expeditions against the raja of Bundelkhand. He ‘thirsted’, in Asad Beg’s words, ‘for the blood of that wretch’. It was a thirst